



App security in India

We sit with **Kunaciilan Nallappan**, Regional Vice President - Marketing, F5 Networks to know about the state of Application Delivery for India.

Mithun Mohandas | mithun@digit.in

Q F5 offers a similar set of services that are already present and included when folks go for a cloud solution. Why would they pay more and go for your services instead?

Kuna: All these cloud service providers are in the business of selling instances and not app services. Since you spoke of AWS, they have a solution called ELB (Elastic Load Balancer) and they make it clear that these are plain vanilla services. In fact, we tell our customers, if you're going to put a non-mission critical app, then you don't need to invest in F5 since you don't need a premium service. However, if you are moving your app in AWS and you want to scale up and protect it with enterprise-level app services, then ELB is akin to a 30-min voice plan. While F5 is like an unlimited voice plan with unlimited data plan with all the works. Let's say you're moving your app to Azure or AWS or Oracle, then they all have their own load balancing services, however, they don't communicate with each other. So if you're looking at security policy management then F5 is consistent across all these services. It all depends on the level of customer experience and consistency of operation that you want.

Q I believe F5 has a Deep Packet Inspection service. If a bad agent were to slip in malicious code into a data stream, can you protect against that.

Kuna: There are various levels of checks that take place. Let's examine this situation. The first is, inserting a malware in the datastream and passing it on. The second is, changing the code itself. It's a bit like having stolen money and black money in your wallet. Both are bad. Black money is bad and stolen money is seemingly good, but bad. There are subtle differences between the two. We are able to decrypt and look into the payload. There are some things that we can't examine. For example, we won't know if what we find is black money. So we have partners like FireEye who'll check the contents and let us know if it is black money or stolen money. This is where the WAF (Web Application Firewall) comes into the picture and identifies the malicious code. Once that's done, we re-encrypt and pass the data packet on.

Q India has had quite a few security lapses in the last year. Could you share any insights about startups. Do they express the same level of interest as big banks towards securing their apps.

Kuna: We do not have a mechanism to track that yet. Startups are pretty agile. They come in and consume us, let's say

on a certain cloud provider, and they move on. It's a bit early in the game to get statistics on that. As the consumption goes up, we'll have a good dataset to analyse. As of right now, we know that they are experimenting. India is a service-oriented country and the app-developing community is very strong here. We're making sure that we are pervasive and making ourselves available in different ways and across different services. So if the startups want something, they can find us.

Q You mentioned that India as a whole has grown more conscious about security. Could you elaborate more on that?

Kuna: The top security challenges remain largely the same, year over year. Indian banks don't just have to deal with security but with something that we call 'security at scale'. Nowhere else in the world, with the exception of China, do banks have to worry about protecting millions and millions of customers. What could happen in a minute in an Indian bank is what a Singaporean bank would experience in a day or even a month. The security at scale is important. It's not just about getting a WAF but getting a WAF that can perform at the level of handling millions of transactions a second. The scaling aspect in India can be sometimes more challenging than the securing aspect. 